



NAMGYAL SHERPA, who manages Ruth Higdon's 120-acre ranch in Colorado, checks on a newborn yak. BENJAMIN RASMUSSEN For The Times

COLUMN ONE

A sliver of Nepal thriving in the Rockies

A retired surgeon and a Sherpa couple live on a yak ranch, one of dozens in Colorado.

BY DAVID KELLY
REPORTING FROM
RIDGWAY, COLO.

Namgyal Sherpa speaks yak. So when a calf disappeared into the tall grass recently, he roamed among the herd making low, rumbling grunts.

Then a few higher-pitched calls.

There was a rustle and a flash of black. A youngster sprang from the grass, running toward its mother, draped in what looked like a roomy shag carpet. She nudged the anxious calf to her side and they trotted briskly away.

Namgyal followed closely behind.

Ruth Higdon watched from the pasture.

"Cows moo, yaks grunt," she explained. "Their Latin name is *Bos grunniens* — grunting ox."

Higdon has been chasing yaks for years. She's worked with them, lived with them and, for the last decade, has been raising them on her ranch, Smiling Buddha Yaks.

It's the grunting culmination of a love affair that began when Higdon, a retired cancer surgeon, encountered a line of yaks in Nepal not far from Mt. Everest.

"They were the most majestic animals I'd ever seen," she said. "They had these big bells around their necks and were dressed up in a way that made them look very regal and a bit ferocious."

The affair continued years later as she ran yak expeditions in Alaska, gleaned wisdom from weather-beaten yak herders in Tibet and studied the finer points of yak husbandry at India's National Research Center on Yak — home of Norgyal, the first test tube yak baby.

Now she breeds her own yaks on 120 acres of pasture, foothills and mesa tops high in bucolic Ridgway, about

[See **Yaks**, A7]

The mystery of the poisoned pines

A rash of bizarre tree killings stirs questions and suspicion in upscale enclave on Lake Tahoe

By Alex Wigglesworth

A bizarre crime rampage has roiled an upscale mountain community on the north shore of Lake Tahoe.

The suspects are unknown. The victims? More than a dozen towering pine trees.

Someone has, on multiple occasions, slipped into a residents-only beach in Incline Village, Nev., drilled holes near the roots of the conifers and poured a chemical inside. At least 10 trees have died, some of them over a century old.

The incidents date to 2022 but have escalated in recent months, with 16 trees poisoned on three occasions since May.

Although investigators haven't determined a motive for the malfeasance, theories abound.

"My gut instinct tells me this is someone that lives nearby that is trying to improve the value of their home," said Lt.

Chad McKinnon of the Washoe County Sheriff's Office, "whether they want to resell it soon so they think maybe this is a way to help improve the lake view to get more money."

Resident Annalise Sandhu has canvassed the neighborhood and taken note of several homes that would gain a clearer sight line from the trees' loss. The co-founder of a startup moved from the Bay Area last year, attracted by the close-knit community and its embrace of the abundant wildlife.

"It's almost like an atrocity, just because we have such respect for nature," she said.

Incline Village — nicknamed "Income Village" — has long had a reputation as a haven for the ultrawealthy. Property owners include Oracle founder Larry Ellison,

[See **Trees**, A6]



SCOTT SADY For The Times

RESIDENT Annalise Sandhu among poisoned trees in Incline Village, Nev.

Two internet giants near union

State considers access, diversity in Charter-Cox deal

BY MEG JAMES

Spectrum owner Charter Communications is nearing the finish line in its long-awaited \$34.5-billion purchase of Cox Enterprises to form the nation's largest internet and cable television company.

California's Public Utilities Commission is scheduled to vote next week to approve the merger that would bolster Southern California's dominant provider with more than 5 million customers. Securing the approval of California regulators — the deal's final hurdle — has been a slog as federal

officials gave Charter their consent months ago.

Customers of privately held Cox, the Atlanta-based company that serves Rancho Palos Verdes, Rolling Hills Estates, Las Vegas and large parts of Orange and San Diego counties, would be switched to Spectrum service. Charter is the industry leader, providing Spectrum internet, phone and cable TV packages for Los Angeles, Riverside, San Bernardino and Ventura counties.

It's been more than a year since the companies unveiled their proposed union, and they hope to combine operations this month. But

flaps have flared up in the last lap.

Public interest groups have argued that the PUC's proposed settlement with Charter doesn't go far enough to ensure long-term affordable internet for low-income residents or accommodations for customers reeling from natural disasters such as last year's Eaton and Palisades fires.

In addition, advocates have asked utilities commissioners to demand that Charter commit to fostering workplace diversity, equity and inclusion among its proposed 9,000-member workforce in California. Such pro-

[See **Merger**, A12]

Trump tries to end birthright citizenship 'a different way'

After Supreme Court loss, two orders aim to narrow eligibility and block 'birth tourism.'

BY KEVIN RECTOR

President Trump has again targeted birthright citizenship, signing a pair of executive orders purporting to narrow it by cracking down on "birth tourism" and limiting which children born to immigrants in the U.S. qualify.

The new orders follow a U.S. Supreme Court ruling in June that rejected an attempt by Trump to end birthright citizenship outright.

During a signing ceremony Thursday in the Oval Office, Trump called that decision by the high court "very unfair" and said the new orders were an attempt to end birthright citizenship by other means.

"Our country suffers be-

cause of it, and we're ending it a different way," he said.

Trump promised "big crackdowns" on birth tourism, or the practice of pregnant foreign women coming to the United States, or foreign men using surrogates already in the U.S., specifically to ensure their children receive U.S. citizenship.

Trump said an entire industry has been built up around the practice, turning birthright citizenship into "a joke."

"Wealthy people are building businesses around birthright citizenship. That's not the way it's supposed to work. It's a disgrace," he said. "They're buying their way in, and we're not going to let it happen."

The orders were immediately criticized by proponents of birthright citizenship as an indefensible attempt by the president and his administration to make an end run around the

[See **Citizenship**, A6]

D.A. criticized for charging officer

Hochman says LAPD cop's secret recordings of bigoted remarks violate state law.

BY LIBOR JANY,
JAMES QUEALLY
AND RICHARD WINTON

In the days since he charged a Los Angeles police officer with a crime for capturing evidence of his co-workers' racist remarks, Los Angeles County Dist. Atty. Nathan Hochman has been the subject of withering criticism from Mayor Karen Bass, former cops and even some of his own prosecutors.

The chorus of voices decrying the filing of 16 counts of felony eavesdropping against Officer Daniel Flores — who caught fellow officers on tape using slurs and making derogatory remarks about Asian, Mexican and Black people, as well as

women in the Los Angeles Police Department's Training Division in 2024 — say the charges will dissuade other officers from reporting corruption and raise questions about Hochman's commitment to police accountability.

"The bottom line is that the alleged racist, sexist, and homophobic comments made are outrageous and unacceptable," Bass said in a statement to The Times on Tuesday. "While I understand that it is inappropriate and a crime to record colleagues without their consent, those charges certainly send the wrong message that calling out egregious behavior could land you in prison."

Six L.A. County prosecutors — all speaking on condition of anonymity in order to discuss the case candidly — also said in recent days they were shocked by Hochman's decision to

[See **Hochman**, A8]



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

UNDER the historic zone designation, new housing projects in Sunset Square can sit empty for years.

Historic preservation and building stagnation

BY JACK FLEMMING

In 2017, Hollywood's Sunset Square was named a Historic Preservation Overlay Zone, solidifying its place in L.A.'s architectural history. Four years later, Lady Gaga's dog walker was shot in the chest outside a vacant house in the middle of the neighborhood.

A small contingent of Sunset Square residents insist the two events are tied together.

A clash is brewing in the affluent enclave, where homes typically sell for

\$2 million or more. Critics of the HPOZ designation claim the rigorous permitting process is a burden, inviting crime as projects stall and houses stay vacant while mired in red tape. Supporters say the HPOZ is a necessary pain in the quest for preservation — the only thing stopping Sunset Square from turning into another flavorless suburb filled with box houses and McMansions.

Ultimately, it's a microcosm of a larger battle playing out across Southern California as cities ask exist-

[See **Sunset**, A9]

Meta must pay \$567 million

In a ruling, New Mexico judge orders the social media giant to make its platform safer for young people. **BUSINESS**, A10

Trump ballroom blocked by court

Federal appeals panel says the project requires congressional approval. Supreme Court is likely to decide. **NATION**, A4

Aspiration deal parallel alleged

Clippers star Kawhi Leonard is reported to have another undisclosed endorsement pact. **SPORTS**, B12

Weather
Mostly sunny; warm.
L.A. Basin: 89/69. **B8**



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